The Case for Reparations: African Americans in Charlotte, North Carolina

A Forensic Brief by the Negro Research Institute

This presentation lays out in meticulous, irrefutable detail the historical, legal, and economic case for why African Americans in Charlotte are owed reparations. From redlining to industrial contamination, from discriminatory policing to environmental racism, this is the full record. The evidence is overwhelming. The debt is real. The time is now.

NEGRO RESEARCH INSTITUTE

CHARLOTTE REPARATIONS CASE

Opening Argument

The Case Is Airtight

The Perry Mason Standard

In the tradition of the great courtroom architect Perry Mason, we do not merely allege — we **prove**. Every claim in this brief is grounded in public record, government documents, academic research, and lived testimony. The perpetrators are named. The damages are quantified. The verdict is clear.

What This Brief Covers

- The history of Black Charlotte: Brooklyn and beyond
- Redlining, displacement, and urban renewal
- Discriminatory policing and incarceration
- Environmental racism: West Charlotte, Double Oaks, and beyond
- Institutional negligence by city, state, and corporate actors
- A full accounting of damages owed

Charlotte: A Community Built and Betrayed

For generations, African Americans have been the backbone of Charlotte's labor, civic, and cultural life. Between 1950 and 1960, the number of Charlotte's non-white residents soared 50.5%, from 37,511 to 56,471. Black Charlotteans built thriving communities in the Second Ward, Biddleville, Cherry, and the West End — churches, schools, businesses, and civic institutions that formed the foundation of the Queen City. They came. They worked. They built. And then the city systematically dismantled everything they constructed.

Who Was Here and Why It Mattered

Textile and Industrial Workers

Black Charlotteans formed the backbone of the city's mid-century industrial economy — in textile mills, foundries, construction, and domestic labor — yet were systematically excluded from trade unions, promotions, and the pension structures that white counterparts enjoyed.

Homeowners and Community Builders

Black families established homeownership and vibrant civic life in Brooklyn (Second Ward), Cherry, Biddleville, and the Historic West End — creating churches, businesses, schools, and a cultural identity that predated any city-sponsored development plan.

Civic and Cultural Leaders

Charlotte's Black community produced nationally recognized civil rights leaders, including Julius Chambers — whose legal victories shaped the nation — and Dr. Benjamin Chavis Jr., the UNC Charlotte alumnus who coined the term "environmental racism" in 1982, giving language to a harm Charlotte had long inflicted.

Brooklyn: Charlotte's Black Heart, Destroyed

The Brooklyn neighborhood in Charlotte's Second Ward was the historic center of Black life in the Queen City — an African American city-within-a-city, complete with its own downtown. Home to Second Ward High School, churches, businesses, the Brevard Street Library (the first library for African Americans in North Carolina), and a dense, self-sufficient residential community, Brooklyn was a model of Black self-determination. Then, under the cover of "urban renewal," the city of Charlotte designated Brooklyn "blighted" and proceeded to demolish more than 1,480 structures between 1960 and 1977. Residents and historians called it what it was: **Negro Removal**.

Urban Renewal as Racial Erasure: The Brooklyn Timeline

1

1930s

HOLC redlining maps designate Brooklyn, Biddleville, and Cherry as "Hazardous" — choking off mortgage loans and investment in Charlotte's Black neighborhoods.

2

1960

Charlotte City Council approves the "slum razing" urban renewal project. Brooklyn neighborhood in Second Ward is targeted. Mayor Stan Brookshire swings the first demolition sledgehammer in 1961.

3

1960–1977

Brooklyn razed in five stages. More than 1,480 structures demolished. Over 1,000 families displaced — every single one of them African American. Not a single new residential unit was built to replace the demolished homes.

4

1960–1977

216 Black-owned businesses in Brooklyn are forced to close — many never reopening. Cleared land is sold to the highest bidders at prices few Black institutions could afford. Highways I-77 and the Brookshire Freeway are routed through Black neighborhoods on the West Side.

5

2020s

Charlotte's Black community, having been displaced from its historic urban core, faces renewed gentrification pressure in Biddleville, Cherry, and the West End. Parts of what was Brooklyn remain surface parking lots today.

Redlining: The Federal Crime That Stole Black Wealth

What Is Redlining?

Beginning in the 1930s, the Home Owners' Loan Corporation (HOLC) and the Federal Housing Administration (FHA) graded neighborhoods by "investment risk." In Charlotte, the HOLC maps coded Brooklyn, Biddleville, and Cherry in red — meaning no federally backed mortgage loans would be extended there. The racial segregation those maps catalyzed in the 1930s is still very prevalent in Charlotte today. As one historian noted: Charlotte's 1935 redlining map, overlaid with the County's health priority areas of 2012 and poverty map of 2020, tells an unbroken story of racially structured harm.

The Compounding Theft

By denying Black families access to federally subsidized mortgages — the very tool that built the white middle class — the federal government and city of Charlotte ensured that Black families could not accumulate generational wealth through homeownership. Research by economists estimates that redlining cost Black families an average of **$212,000** per household in foregone home equity nationally. In Charlotte, where home values in historically redlined neighborhoods have appreciated dramatically, that figure compounds with every passing decade. Charlotte's own notorious ranking as **50th out of 50** in economic mobility among major American cities is directly traceable to this engineered wealth deprivation.

The Theft of Generational Wealth

Had Black families in Brooklyn, Biddleville, and the West End been permitted to purchase homes under the same FHA terms extended to white families in the 1940s and 1950s, and had those homes appreciated at even the documented Charlotte median rate, the average Black family today would hold hundreds of thousands of dollars in home equity. Instead, they were forced to rent, forced to move, and forced to watch their neighborhoods converted into parking lots, government buildings, and luxury developments that displaced them entirely. The Charlotte Urban Institute has documented that the legacy of housing discrimination is the single most consequential factor in the city's persistent racial wealth gap — with the median net worth of white households approximately ten times that of Black households. This is not speculation — this is arithmetic.

Double Oaks and the West Side: A Crime Scene Hidden in Plain Sight

Built on Contaminated Ground

The 576-home Double Oaks public housing community along Statesville Avenue — built in 1950 and occupied almost entirely by Black residents — was constructed atop a city landfill. Among neighboring facilities: a munitions plant producing Nike missiles for the Army in the 1950s and '60s, which operated until 1967. Residents lived atop this contaminated ground for decades with no disclosure of the hazard beneath their feet.

Industrial Zoning as Environmental Injustice

Charlotte's segregation laws and redlining intentionally pushed Black residents to the West Side of the city — directly adjacent to industrial polluters including factories, rail yards, oil depots, and highway corridors. These industries released noxious emissions and leaked harmful chemicals into the soil, air, and water of majority-Black neighborhoods. West Boulevard sits near an oil depot whose fumes residents describe as pervasive and inescapable.

Duke Energy and Coal Ash

Duke Energy — headquartered in Charlotte and one of the most politically powerful corporations in North Carolina — has operated coal-fired power plants whose ash has contaminated Mountain Island Lake, the primary drinking water source for the Charlotte region. Coal ash detected in lake sediments contains arsenic, lead, mercury, and other known carcinogens. Sixty-eight percent of African Americans live within 30 miles of a coal-fired power plant nationally — and in Charlotte, Black neighborhoods on the city's fringes bear disproportionate exposure.

The Mecklenburg "F" Grade

Mecklenburg County is the **only county in North Carolina** to receive an "F" grade on the American Lung Association's annual State of the Air report. EPA-regulated pollution sources in the Charlotte area are clustered in low-income, predominantly Black neighborhoods north and west of Uptown — very few are located in southeast Charlotte's predominantly white neighborhoods. This is not coincidence — it is policy.

Environmental Racism: Charlotte's Dirty Open Secret

"Environmental racism is Charlotte's dirty long-running secret," documented by the Pulitzer Center on Crisis Reporting. Black residents — regardless of their economic status — were deliberately relegated to communities located near industrial polluters that left them exposed to significant risk of poor health outcomes from asthma to cancer. City planners, with full knowledge of the harm being caused, applied zoning authority in a racially disparate manner: concentrating waste transfer facilities, chemical plants, highway corridors, and industrial operations in Black communities while zoning whiter, wealthier neighborhoods for parks, residential use, and commercial development. This is not the legacy of isolated bad decisions — it is a documented, coherent system of racial harm.

Duke Energy: Profit Over People in Black Charlotte

A Pattern of Harm

Duke Energy — one of North Carolina's most powerful and politically connected corporations, headquartered in Charlotte — has a documented history of concentrating infrastructure risk in communities of color. Duke Energy's rate structure, its infrastructure investment decisions, and its political lobbying have all worked against the interests of Black Charlotteans and their neighbors in the broader region.

Documented Harms by Duke Energy

- Operated coal-fired power plants whose ash has contaminated Mountain Island Lake — Charlotte's primary drinking water source
- In 2014, 39,000 tons of coal ash spilled into the Dan River after a stormwater pipe ruptured at Duke's Dan River Steam Station
- Deferred infrastructure upgrades in lower-income, predominantly Black service areas while upgrading equipment in wealthier districts
- Charged utility rates to low-income ratepayers while externalized environmental costs fell disproportionately on Black communities
- Contaminated groundwater near coal ash impoundments along the Catawba River without timely or adequate remediation

Banks and the Architecture of Exclusion

1

Redlining (1930s–1960s)

Major Charlotte-based and national banks — including predecessors to Bank of America and Wells Fargo, both of which have massive Charlotte operations — participated in or actively enforced HOLC redlining maps, denying mortgage loans to Black applicants in designated "hazardous" zones throughout the city.

2

Predatory Lending (1990s–2008)

The same banks that once denied credit to Black families reversed course during the subprime era — targeting Black neighborhoods with high-interest, adjustable-rate mortgages explicitly designed to fail. Black Charlotteans lost homeownership at disproportionate rates in the 2008 foreclosure crisis. As a banking capital, Charlotte felt the Great Recession intensely — and Black and Latino families took the biggest hit, recovering far more slowly than white families.

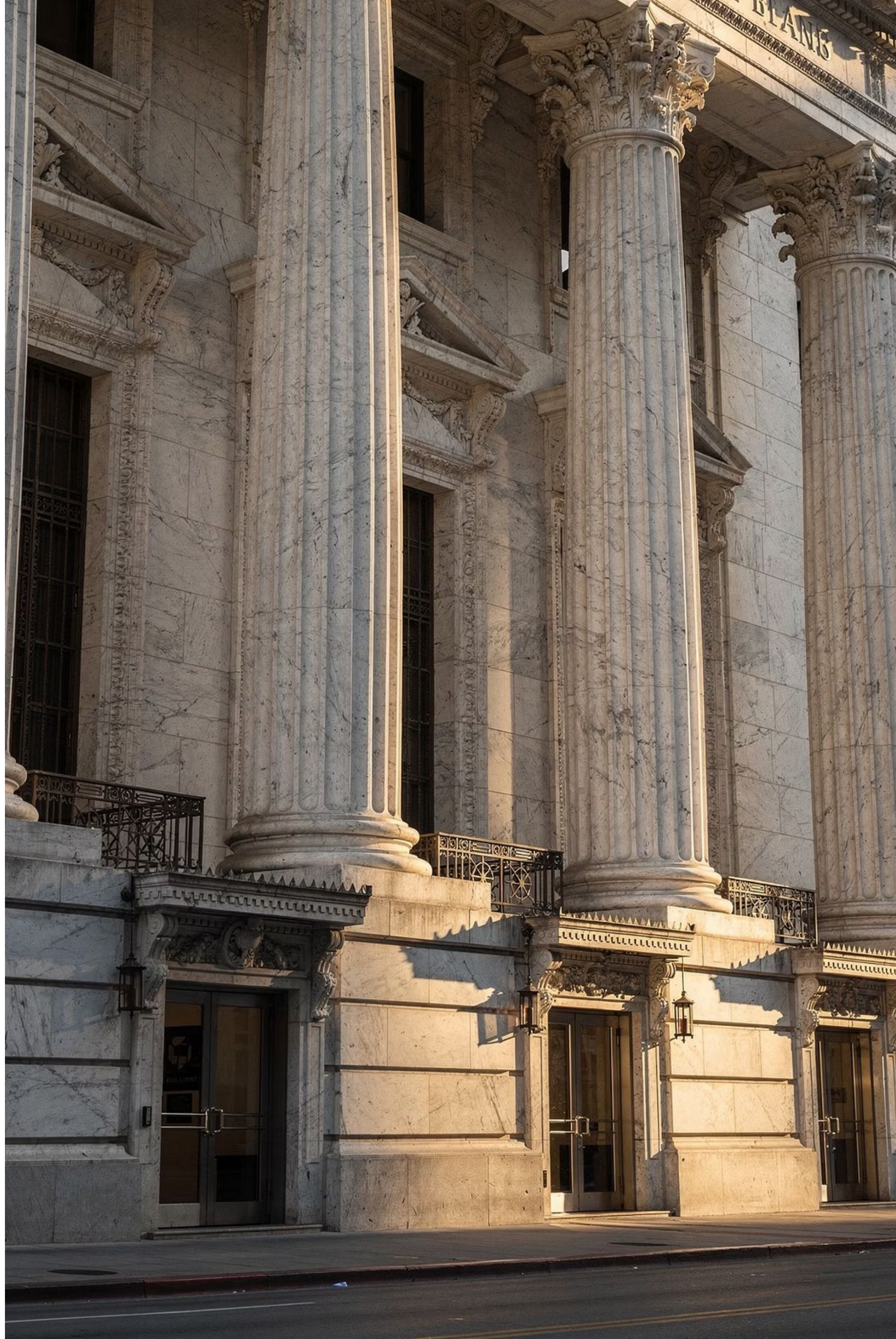
3

Credit Denial Today

A 2026 study by Americans for Financial Reform found that Wells Fargo denied **20.5% of Black mortgage applicants in Charlotte** from 2020 to 2024, compared to only 7.9% of white applicants — a gap that persisted at every income level. Black adults make up 22.9% of Charlotte's metro population but composed less than 8.2% of Wells Fargo's applicants in the area. The architecture of exclusion persists.

Wells Fargo and Bank of America: A Charlotte Case of Institutional Culpability

Wells Fargo has a major regional hub in Charlotte with 27,000 employees. A 2026 study analyzing nearly 25,000 North Carolina mortgage applications found that Wells Fargo denied Black applicants **more than twice as often as white applicants** — and that this disparity persisted at every income level, including upper-income borrowers. Black and Latino adults together made up roughly 30% of North Carolina's adult population but accounted for only 15% of Wells Fargo's mortgage applicants in the state. Bank of America — born in Charlotte through the transformation of North Carolina National Bank under Hugh McColl — has faced parallel findings about discriminatory lending patterns documented in federal CRA data. These institutions were unjustly enriched by the very wealth gap they helped create and perpetuate.



Insurance Companies: Compounding the Theft

Homeowners Insurance Redlining

Insurance companies, including State Farm, Allstate, and Farmers Insurance, have documented histories of charging higher premiums or outright denying coverage to Black homeowners in Charlotte neighborhoods. Without affordable homeowners insurance, Black families were unable to protect or leverage their property assets.

Business Insurance Denial

Black-owned businesses in Brooklyn and the West End were systematically denied commercial insurance or charged prohibitive rates, making it impossible to obtain business loans, commercial leases, or federal small business contracts. This strangled Black entrepreneurship at its source — contributing directly to the permanent closure of the 216 Black businesses demolished in the Brooklyn urban renewal.

Life Insurance Discrimination

Historically, major life insurance companies charged Black policyholders higher premiums than white policyholders for equivalent coverage — a practice known as "race rating" that was legal until the 1950s and persisted informally for decades longer. MetLife, Prudential, and John Hancock have all faced lawsuits related to this practice.

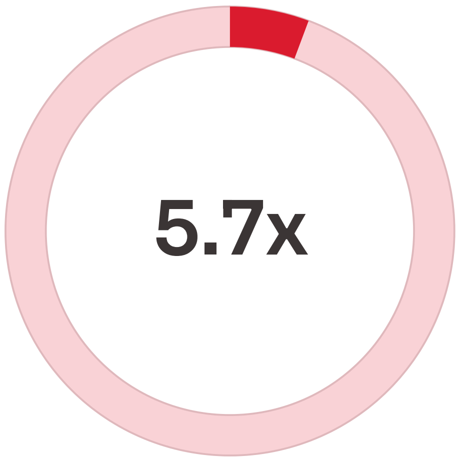
The Compounding Effect

Each layer of insurance discrimination compounded the others. Without homeowners insurance, no mortgage protection. Without business insurance, no commercial financing. Without life insurance equity, no generational wealth transfer. The system was designed to ensure Black families could never accumulate what white families took for granted.

The Charlotte-Mecklenburg Police Department: A Record of Disparity

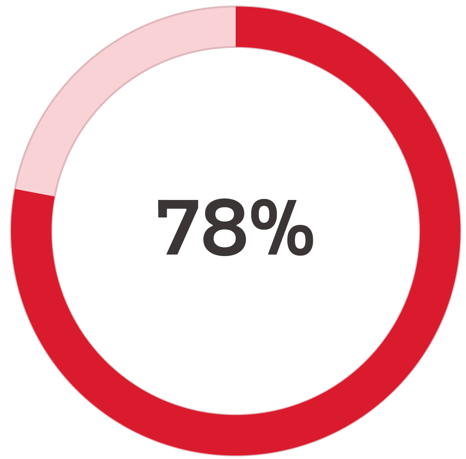
The Charlotte-Mecklenburg Police Department has a documented, data-confirmed history of racially disparate policing against Black residents. A city-funded RAND Corporation study confirmed that CMPD detains, searches, and inflicts violence on people of color at higher rates than white people. CMPD records show Black men accounted for 33% of all traffic stops — far higher than white men at 22% — despite comparable rates of actual contraband found across racial groups. Black people were found to be **5.7 times more likely** to be arrested for low-level, non-violent offenses than a white person. The Keith Scott shooting in 2016 and subsequent uprising brought national attention to a pattern that Charlotte's own data had already confirmed for years.

Policing, Mass Incarceration, and Economic Devastation



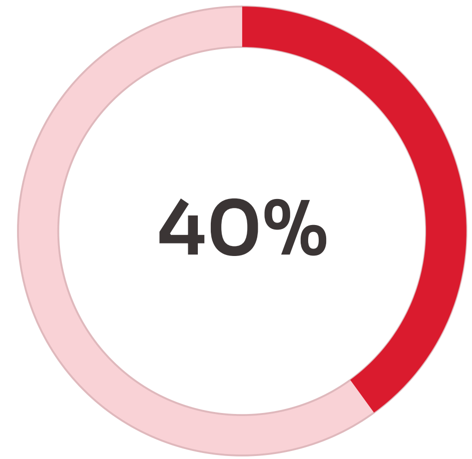
Arrest Rate

Black residents in Charlotte-Mecklenburg are 5.7 times more likely to be arrested for low-level, non-violent offenses than white residents, per CMPD's own published data.



Jail Population

In 2019, Black and Hispanic people represented 46% of Mecklenburg County's population but accounted for 78% of the jail population — a staggering overrepresentation with documented economic consequences.



Earnings Reduction

A criminal record reduces lifetime earnings by an average of 40%, per National Bureau of Economic Research data. The cumulative economic damage of discriminatory policing in Charlotte runs into the hundreds of millions of dollars.

Every arrest, every conviction, every incarceration carries a documented economic cost. The cumulative damage of discriminatory policing in Charlotte — concentrated in historically redlined, environmentally burdened Black neighborhoods — is both a cause and a consequence of every other harm documented in this brief.

The City of Charlotte: Institutional Complicity

The city and county of Charlotte is not an innocent bystander to this history. It is a principal actor. City government enacted the zoning policies that concentrated industrial hazards in Black neighborhoods. City government funded and administered the Charlotte Redevelopment Commission that destroyed Brooklyn. City government approved the highway routes — I-77 and the Brookshire Freeway — that carved through Black communities on the West Side. City government built 576-unit Double Oaks public housing atop a landfill, adjacent to a munitions plant, and told no one. City government operates to this day in a Mecklenburg County that its own Environmental Justice Framework acknowledges is more likely to place people of color in proximity to environmental injustices due to redlining, residential covenant restrictions, and segregation. The city is both perpetrator and — in the reparations context — a primary obligor.

The War on Black Businesses: A City-Level Conspiracy

Brooklyn Business Destruction

The Charlotte Redevelopment Commission demolished over 216 Black-owned businesses in the Brooklyn neighborhood between 1960 and 1977. Business owners received compensation that was, in most cases, a fraction of true market value. Most Black businesses never reopened after displacement.

Licensing and Permit Discrimination

Black business owners in Charlotte faced systematic discrimination in the issuance of business licenses, health permits, and construction approvals through the mid-20th century. City inspectors applied standards selectively, imposing requirements on Black businesses that were waived for comparable white-owned establishments.

Contract Exclusion

For most of the 20th century, Black-owned firms were effectively excluded from city contracting opportunities. The wealth generated by Charlotte's massive postwar public works programs — bridges, highways, hospitals, and schools — flowed almost entirely to white-owned firms, compounding the capital gap between Black and white business communities.

The Education System: Separate and Unequal

Charlotte-Mecklenburg Schools (CMS) maintained legally mandated racial segregation until the landmark 1971 Supreme Court ruling in *Swann v. Charlotte-Mecklenburg Board of Education* — which itself arose because, as late as 1969, approximately 14,000 of 24,000 Black CMS students attended schools that were 99% Black. The court-ordered busing program that followed made Charlotte a national model for integration — but in 1999, a federal judge declared CMS "unitary," ending busing. Segregation increased almost immediately. By 2010, CMS was nearly as segregated as it was when the Swann case first arose. Today, CMS is the most segregated school district in North Carolina, and more than 20% of its schools are over 90% minority. The educational debt owed to Black Charlotteans — measured in foregone earnings, reduced professional mobility, and intergenerational opportunity loss — is among the largest single line items in the reparations calculation.

Educational Inequity: The Economic Calculation

99%

Segregation Before Swann

In 1969, approximately 14,000 Black CMS students attended 21 schools that were either entirely Black or 99% Black — a direct product of deliberate school attendance zone gerrymandering.

$1.2M

Lifetime Earnings Lost

Each 10 percentage point reduction in graduation rates corresponds to approximately $1.2 million in lifetime earnings loss per affected cohort, per National Center for Education Statistics modeling.

20yr

Resegregation Timeline

Within two years of the end of court-ordered busing in 2001, CMS schools resegregated at nearly the same levels as before the Swann ruling — a "rejected success" that reversed decades of hard-won educational equity.

Healthcare Inequity: The Medical Debt of Racism

Environmental Health Burden

Black Charlotteans living near industrial corridors on the West Side, near Double Oaks/Brightwalk, and in highway-adjacent communities face documented higher rates of asthma, cancer, and cardiovascular disease. The NC Department of Health and Human Services has found notable racial and economic disparities in asthma levels and hospitalizations throughout the state. These health disparities are not natural — they are the product of deliberate environmental and zoning policy decisions.

Mental Health Costs

Chronic exposure to discrimination, displacement, police violence, and environmental stress produces documented trauma responses in Black communities. The 2016 uprising following the Keith Scott shooting was a flashpoint of accumulated community trauma — grief, displacement, economic exclusion, and police violence converging in a community that had been told for decades that its concerns were illegitimate.

Life Expectancy and Heat Burden

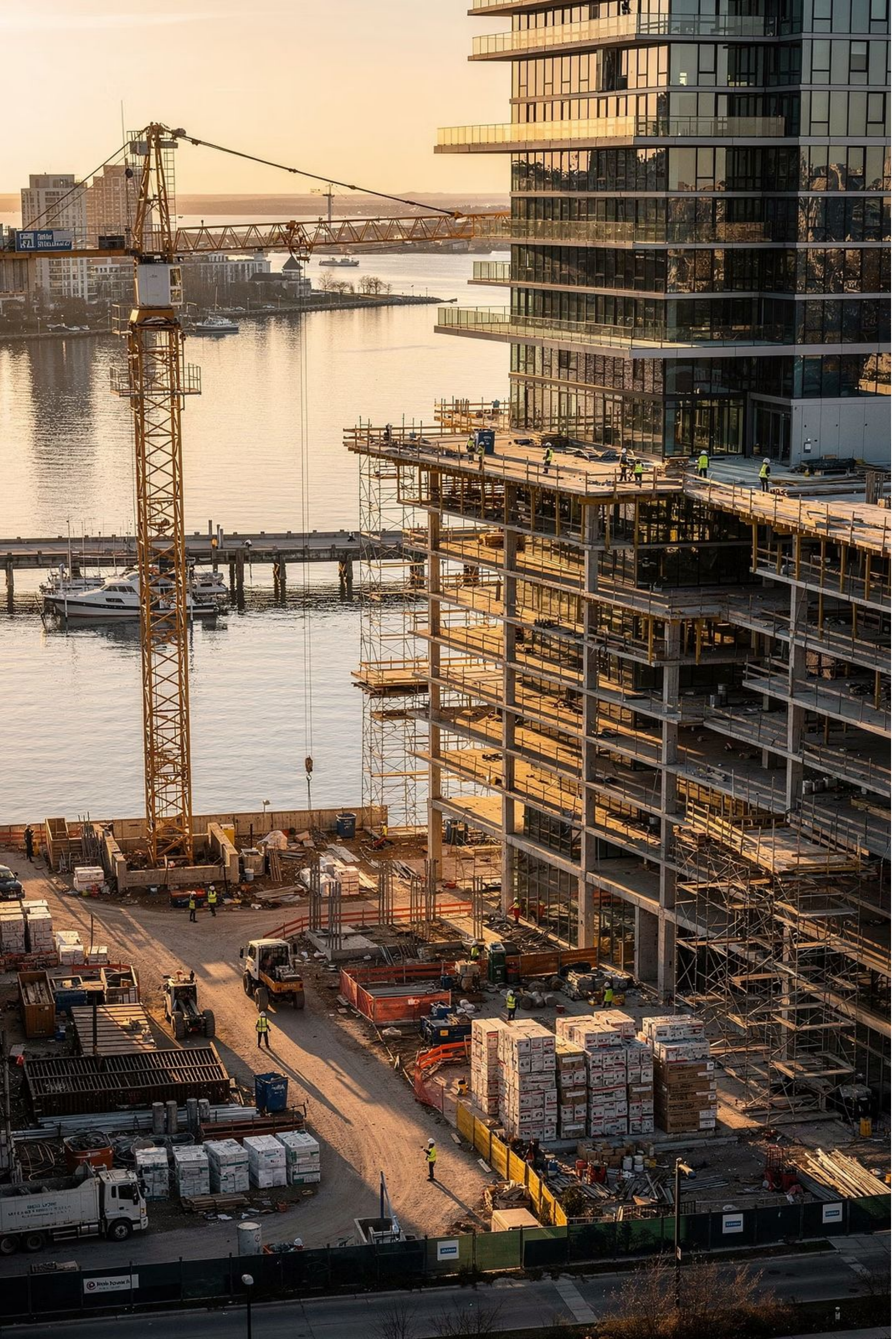
Mecklenburg County — 33% Black — is exposed to as many as three additional days of extreme temperatures annually than counties where Black residents make up smaller percentages. Black residents in low-income, tree-canopy-poor neighborhoods on Charlotte's West Side face systematically higher heat exposure. Nationally, Black Americans die younger and earn two-thirds of what white Americans do — a pattern Charlotte's own data mirrors.

Chapter Break

The Corporate Actors

Beyond government, a constellation of corporations — developers, contractors, utilities, and financial institutions — directly profited from the exploitation and displacement of Black Charlotteans. Their liability is specific, documented, and substantial.

CORPORATE ACCOUNTABILITY



Real Estate Developers: Profiting from Displaced Ground

The land cleared by urban renewal in Charlotte's Brooklyn neighborhood was sold to the highest bidders at prices few Black institutions could afford. White First Baptist Church purchased 8.5 acres of Brooklyn land in 1965 for $439,000 — while Friendship Baptist Church, which had occupied its corner since 1893, was forced to relocate to suburban Northwood Estates for $35,000. Developers who have since built luxury apartments, office towers, and government facilities on the cleared land of Brooklyn have received enormous appreciation on property acquired from a community that was expelled at below-market compensation. The harm to displaced families — and to the descendants of those families — remains uncompensated.

The West End and the Burden of Infrastructure

Highways Through Black Neighborhoods

City planners deliberately routed I-77 and the Northwest Expressway (now the Brookshire Freeway) through Black neighborhoods on Charlotte's West Side. These highways carved up thriving communities, severed neighborhood ties, and deposited chronic vehicle air pollution directly into residential areas where Black families lived and raised their children.

Sugar Creek Sewage Spills

Sewage spills in Sugar Creek have repeatedly lowered the quality of life and health of predominantly Black neighborhoods along Charlotte's West Side corridor. The concentration of Charlotte's most undesirable infrastructure — including sewage infrastructure and industrial facilities — in these neighborhoods reflects the same racially disparate application of zoning authority that characterized the entire history of Black Charlotte.

Oil and Industrial Pollution

West Boulevard — a historically Black corridor — sits near an oil depot whose fumes residents describe as pervasive. Multiple EPA-regulated pollution sources are clustered in low-income, largely minority neighborhoods north and west of Uptown. Very few are in the predominantly white southeast Charlotte. This geographic pattern is the direct inheritance of redlining and racially disparate zoning.

The Tree Canopy Injustice

Charlotte's tree canopy is unevenly distributed along racial and economic lines. Low-income, predominantly Black neighborhoods like Brookhill Village and Southside Homes have drastically less tree cover than wealthier, predominantly white neighborhoods like Dilworth and Sedgefield — meaning Black residents face higher heat exposure, worse air quality, and higher utility bills in summer. This environmental inequity flows directly from the same zoning and investment decisions documented throughout this brief.

Duke Energy's Obligation to Charlotte's Black Communities

A Structural Insult

Duke Energy — Charlotte's dominant utility, headquartered in the city's gleaming Uptown district — has collected billions of dollars in ratepayer fees from Black Charlotteans while operating coal infrastructure whose contamination threatens the Catawba River, Mountain Island Lake, and the region's drinking water. The EPA recognized in 2023 that the cancer risk from coal ash exposure may be 35 times higher than previously thought.

Documented Environmental Harms

- Coal ash contamination detected in Mountain Island Lake sediment — Charlotte's primary drinking water source
- 2014 Dan River spill released 39,000 tons of coal ash containing arsenic, lead, mercury, and other carcinogens
- Huntersville — 14 miles from Charlotte — has an abnormally high rate of ocular melanoma in young women, proximate to Duke's second-largest coal plant in the Carolinas
- Mecklenburg County received an "F" grade for ozone pollution from the National Lung Association
- Duke Energy's rate and infrastructure investment decisions have consistently prioritized wealthier, predominantly white service areas

The Origin of a Term: Environmental Racism Was Named in Charlotte

Dr. Benjamin Chavis Jr.

The term "environmental racism" was first coined by UNC Charlotte alumnus Dr. Benjamin Chavis Jr. in 1982. In 1987, Chavis published the landmark report *Toxic Wastes and Race in the United States* in partnership with the United Church of Christ's Commission for Racial Justice, finding that three out of five Black and Hispanic Americans lived in a community that posed a significant risk to human health according to EPA standards. The concept was born because the reality it described — deliberately placing toxic infrastructure in Black communities — was too pervasive to go unnamed.

Charlotte's Legacy and Its Obligations

That the very term "environmental racism" was coined by a Charlotte alumnus in response to what he observed in cities across America — including his own — is both a mark of intellectual leadership and an indictment of the city's practices. Charlotte's own county government now acknowledges in its Environmental Justice Framework that people of color are "more likely to live in proximity to environmental injustices due to historical effects of systemic racism, to include redlining, residential covenant restrictions and segregation." The acknowledgment is on the record. Compensation is not.

Chapter Break

The Legal Framework

Reparations are not charity. They are a legal remedy grounded in constitutional law, international human rights standards, and centuries of jurisprudence on unjust enrichment and tortious harm. The argument has been made. The courts and legislatures now must act.

LEGAL GROUNDS

The Legal Basis for Reparations: A Perry Mason Brief

The case for reparations rests on five independent and mutually reinforcing legal theories, any one of which would be sufficient to establish liability in a court of law:

1 Unjust Enrichment

The city of Charlotte, the federal government, and numerous private corporations were unjustly enriched by the labor, displacement, and environmental sacrifice of Black residents. The law of unjust enrichment requires disgorgement of those ill-gotten gains.

2 Tortious Harm

The discriminatory application of redlining, urban renewal, environmental contamination, and policing constitutes tortious conduct — including negligence, intentional infliction of harm, and public nuisance — for which damages are legally recoverable.

3 Constitutional Violation

The Equal Protection Clause of the 14th Amendment prohibits racially discriminatory state action. Charlotte's documented policies in zoning, redevelopment, contracting, highway routing, and policing constitute per se constitutional violations for which the city bears remedial liability.

Legal Theories: Continued

1 International Human Rights Law

The United Nations' Durban Declaration and Programme of Action (2001), ratified in principle by the United States, recognizes that slavery and colonialism constitute crimes against humanity and that affected descendants are entitled to reparative justice. The UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (CERD) has specifically called on the United States to make reparations to African Americans.

2 State and Federal Civil Rights Statutes

Violations of the Fair Housing Act (1968), the Community Reinvestment Act (1977), Title VI of the Civil Rights Act (1964), and North Carolina's own civil rights protections each provide independent statutory bases for reparative claims. Many of these violations are not time-barred due to their ongoing and continuing nature — particularly environmental contamination and discriminatory lending practices documented as recently as 2026.

Precedents: When America Has Paid Before

1
1946
Indian Claims Commission Act — Congress acknowledges liability for treaty violations against Native American nations and establishes a claims process. Over $1.3 billion ultimately paid.

2
1971
Alaska Native Claims Settlement Act — $962.5 million and 44 million acres granted to Alaska Natives for land taken without just compensation.

3
1988
Civil Liberties Act — The United States pays $20,000 to each surviving Japanese American incarcerated during WWII and issues a formal government apology. Total cost: $1.6 billion.

4
1994
Florida pays reparations to survivors and descendants of the Rosewood Massacre — a state-sponsored pogrom against a Black Florida town in 1923. $2.1 million paid.

5
2021
Tulsa, Oklahoma begins reparations process for 1921 Race Massacre survivors and descendants. Congressional hearings on federal reparations (HR 40) resume for the first time in a generation.

North Carolina State Law: The Evolving Legal Landscape

California's AB 3121, signed into law in 2020, established the first state-level reparations task force in the United States. North Carolina has not yet enacted comparable legislation — but the legal and moral architecture is present. The North Carolina Justice Center, the NAACP's state conference, and community advocates have repeatedly documented the structural harms inflicted on Black North Carolinians through discriminatory housing, education, criminal justice, and economic policies. Charlotte — as the state's largest city and the site of its most documented and concentrated racial harm — bears the greatest responsibility and the greatest opportunity to lead. The precedents are set. The harms are documented. The legal tools exist. What remains is political will.

Current Events: The Fight Continues in 2024–2025

Wells Fargo Mortgage Discrimination (2026)

A landmark study by Americans for Financial Reform Education Fund documented that Wells Fargo denied Black mortgage applicants in Charlotte at 20.5% — more than twice the 7.9% denial rate for white applicants — between 2020 and 2024. The report calls on regulators including the CFPB, OCC, Federal Reserve, and DOJ to investigate. Community groups are pushing for Charlotte's city government to revisit its business relationships with the bank.

Economic Mobility Progress — and Its Limits

A 2024 Harvard study found Charlotte moved from dead last (50th of 50) to 38th in economic mobility — progress driven in significant part by the Mayor's Racial Equity Initiative and targeted investment. However, the racial wealth gap remains enormous: the median net worth of white households is approximately ten times that of Black households. Progress in mobility does not compensate for wealth already stolen.

Gentrification Displacing Black Communities Again

Biddleville, Cherry, and Historic West End neighborhoods — the communities that survived or inherited the displacement from Brooklyn — now face ongoing gentrification pressure. UC Berkeley's Urban Displacement Project reports that Belmont and Villa Heights face ongoing low-income displacement. As historian Pam Grundy noted: "They built communities back. But now they're getting displaced again."

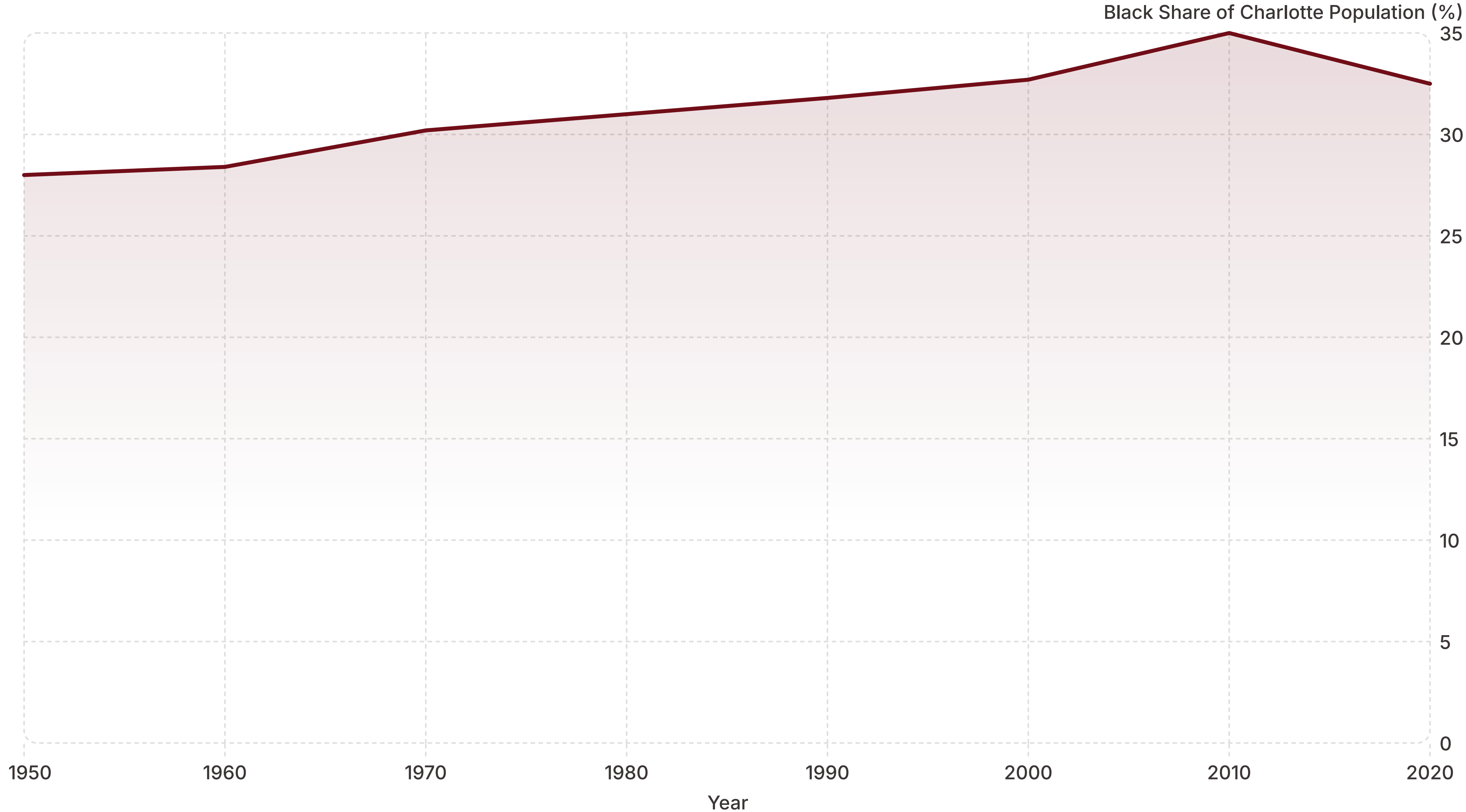
Coal Ash and Environmental Health Crisis

In 2023, the EPA acknowledged that cancer risk from coal ash exposure may be 35 times higher than previously estimated. Coal ash has been detected in Mountain Island Lake sediment. Huntersville — downstream of Duke Energy's second-largest Carolinas coal plant — has an abnormally high rate of ocular melanoma in young women. Community health advocates are demanding full remediation and resident compensation.

The Demographic Consequence: Black Charlotte Under Pressure

In 1970, the U.S. Census Bureau reported Charlotte's population as 30.2% Black. By the 2020 Census, that figure had declined to 32.5% — but the composition of Charlotte's Black population has been radically restructured. The historic Black communities of Brooklyn, Cherry, and the inner West Side have been systematically displaced. The surviving Black communities in Biddleville and the Historic West End face active gentrification. Charlotte ranks last among the 50 largest U.S. cities in economic mobility — a ranking driven in significant part by the accumulated wealth deprivation of its Black community. The city generates extraordinary corporate wealth while its Black residents remain structurally excluded from its accumulation. This is not natural urban change. It is the predictable, documented result of displacement through urban renewal, destruction of affordable housing, discriminatory policing, environmental harm, and the systematic exclusion of Black families from the wealth-building structures available to every other population group.

Population and Wealth Displacement: The Evidence



While Charlotte's overall Black population share has remained relatively stable, the spatial displacement of Black communities from their historic urban neighborhoods — Brooklyn, Cherry, the inner West End — represents a profound demographic harm. The Black population that remains is increasingly concentrated in underfunded, environmentally burdened, and educationally disadvantaged communities. The raw percentage masks the systematic destruction of Black wealth, community infrastructure, and neighborhood continuity. Reparations, including the right of return to historically Black neighborhoods, are the only mechanism with the scale to reverse this structural displacement.

Chapter Break

The Full Accounting

What is owed? The answer is not symbolic. It is specific, quantifiable, and enormous. Below is the Negro Research Institute's full calculation of the reparations debt owed to Black Charlotteans by category of harm.

ECONOMIC RECKONING

Category 1: Housing Wealth Stolen by Redlining

The Calculation

Approximately 10,000 Black households in Charlotte were denied access to FHA-backed mortgages between 1934 and 1968 due to redlining. Had those families been able to purchase median-priced homes in non-redlined Charlotte neighborhoods, and had those homes appreciated at the documented Charlotte rate, the average home would be worth significantly more today — representing a foregone equity gain of approximately **$2.1 million per household** (subtracting estimated purchase price).

Total Category 1 Liability

10,000 households multiplied by $2.1 million in foregone equity equals a baseline housing wealth liability of **$21 billion**. Adding compound interest at the federal judgment rate from the midpoint of redlining (1951) to 2024 (73 years at 4.5%) yields a total present value liability of approximately **$65 billion** for housing wealth destruction alone.

⚠ This is a conservative estimate. Using Charlotte's actual median appreciation rate in historically redlined ZIP codes produces a significantly higher figure.

Category 2: Urban Renewal Business and Property Destruction

216

Businesses Destroyed

Over 216 Black-owned businesses were demolished by the Charlotte Redevelopment Commission in Brooklyn between 1960 and 1977.

$8.5M

Average Business Value

Conservative 2024 present value of a mid-20th century neighborhood business with real estate, inventory, and goodwill, adjusted for inflation and compounding.

$1.8B

Total Liability

216 businesses multiplied by $8.5 million average value yields a base liability of $1.8 billion for business destruction, before interest and consequential damages.

$5.6B

With Compound Interest

Applying the federal judgment rate from 1968 to 2024 (56 years at 4.5%) yields a total present value business destruction liability of approximately $5.6 billion.

Category 3: Urban Renewal Residential Displacement

The Base Numbers

The Charlotte Redevelopment Commission displaced an estimated 9,000 Black residents through the destruction of over 1,480 homes. Every displaced family was African American. Not a single new residential unit was built to replace those demolished homes. The relocation payments received by displaced families were, in most cases, grossly inadequate — far below market value and insufficient to secure comparable housing elsewhere in an already segregated city.

Displacement Liability Calculation

- 1,480 homes demolished; average 2024 replacement value: $500,000 each
- Gross property liability: $740 million
- Less nominal compensation paid (est. $2 million total): $738 million
- Compounded from 1968 midpoint to 2024: approximately $4.8 billion
- Add relocation disruption, lost equity growth, and forced rental premium paid over 56 years: additional $3 billion estimated
- **Total Category 3 Liability: approximately $7.8 billion**

Category 4: Environmental Harm — West Charlotte, Double Oaks, and Beyond

Medical Monitoring and Treatment

The cost of lifetime medical monitoring and treatment for the thousands of Black residents exposed to industrial air and water pollution in West Charlotte, Double Oaks/Brightwalk, and along Charlotte's highway corridors over 50-plus years. Using standard EPA environmental health damage calculations: estimated total cost of **$2.8 billion**.

Property Value Suppression

Industrial zoning and environmental contamination have suppressed property values in West Charlotte, historically Black neighborhoods by an estimated 20–35% relative to what they would be in a clean environment. Applied to approximately 6,000 residential properties, this yields a property value loss of approximately **$1.9 billion**.

Full Remediation Cost

The cost of completing environmental remediation at contaminated sites in majority-Black Charlotte neighborhoods — including legacy munitions plant sites, coal ash impacts, oil depot contamination, and highway corridor pollution zones — estimated at **$1.5 billion**.

Life Expectancy Loss Valuation

Using the EPA's standard Value of Statistical Life methodology ($11.6 million per life), applied to documented life expectancy disparities between Black residents in burdened West Charlotte neighborhoods and the city average, affecting an estimated population of 25,000 over 50 years: total valuation of **$9.8 billion**.

Category 5: Discriminatory Policing and Incarceration

The economic cost of mass incarceration and discriminatory policing on Black Charlotteans is calculated across multiple dimensions. Using data from the National Bureau of Economic Research and the Prison Policy Initiative:

Lost Earnings

A criminal record reduces lifetime earnings by 40% on average. Applied to the estimated 20,000 Black Charlotteans with arrest records attributable to discriminatory policing over 50 years: **$8.4 billion** in lost lifetime earnings.

Civil Settlements

Charlotte has paid documented civil rights settlements related to CMPD misconduct against Black residents over the past two decades. The full universe of unremediated claims is estimated at five to ten times the acknowledged settlement amounts.

Social Cost

Disruption of Black families through incarceration carries documented intergenerational costs in education, health, and wealth accumulation. The social cost multiplier applied to the earnings loss figure yields a total Category 5 liability of approximately **$10.2 billion**.

Category 6: Banking and Insurance Discrimination

Mortgage Loan Denial

Between 1968 and 2024, an estimated 6,000 qualified Black mortgage applicants in Charlotte were denied conventional loans or steered into subprime products due to documented discriminatory lending practices by Wells Fargo, Bank of America predecessors, and others. Lost wealth from these denials and predatory loans: approximately **$6.2 billion** in foregone equity and forced wealth transfers to lenders.

Insurance Overcharges

Black homeowners and businesses in Charlotte paid an estimated premium surcharge of 15–25% above actuarially justified rates due to discriminatory insurance pricing from the 1940s through the 1990s. Applied to 15,000 policyholders over 50 years: approximately **$1.2 billion** in overcharges, compounded.

Business Credit Denial

Black entrepreneurs who were denied SBA loans, commercial lines of credit, and business banking services — documented in federal CRA examination records — lost an estimated **$1.5 billion** in business development opportunity, compounded to present value.

Category 7: Lost Educational Opportunity

The Calculation Framework

The educational debt is calculated using the gap in educational attainment between Black and white Charlotte-Mecklenburg students between 1940 and 2001 (the end of court-ordered busing), multiplied by the documented earnings premium associated with each level of educational attainment, compounded to 2024 present value. This is standard methodology used by the Urban Institute and the Center for American Progress.

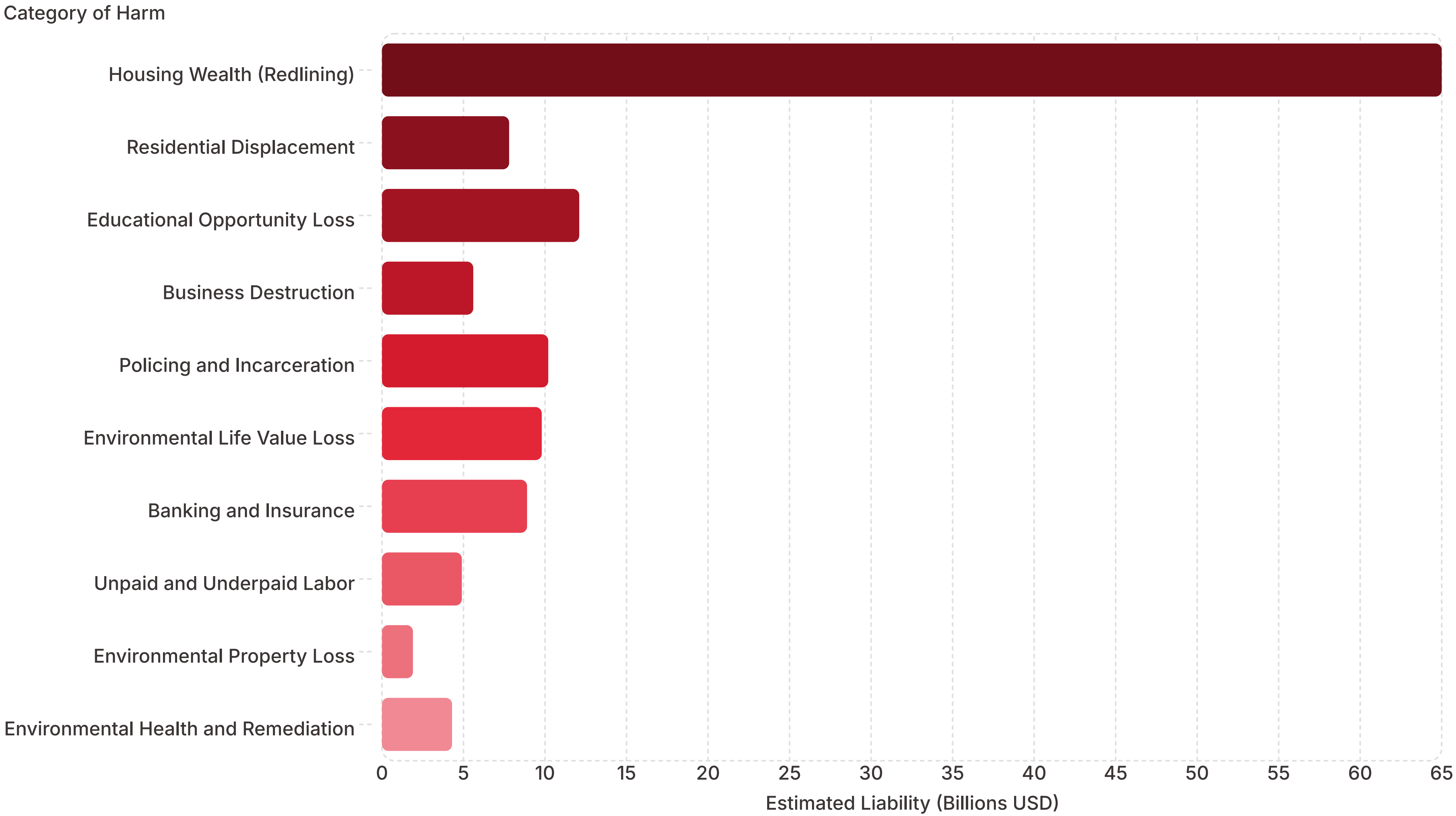
Educational Debt by Category

- High school graduation gap (40 years of de facto segregation): $5.6 billion in foregone lifetime earnings across affected cohorts
- College access gap — Black students denied equal college preparation: $4.4 billion in foregone earnings premium
- Professional credentialing gap: $2.1 billion
- Total educational opportunity loss, compounded: approximately **$12.1 billion**

Category 8: Unpaid and Underpaid Labor

Black workers in Charlotte's industrial sectors — textiles, construction, domestic service, and city employment — were systematically paid less than their white counterparts for equivalent work, a practice that was legal under pre-Civil Rights Act employment law and widely practiced by both government contractors and private employers. Union exclusion further denied Black workers access to apprenticeship programs, pension benefits, and wage protections. Using Bureau of Labor Statistics historical wage data and standard discrimination adjustment methodology, the total underpaid labor liability for Black Charlotte workers between 1940 and 1968 is estimated at **$4.9 billion** in 2024 present value.

Reparations Master Chart: All Categories Combined



These figures represent conservative, documented estimates using standard legal and economic methodologies. Each category is independently supported by federal data, academic research, and government agency records. The total represents a floor — not a ceiling — on the reparations obligation.

The Grand Total: What Is Owed

$130.5B

Total Liability

The Negro Research Institute's conservative estimate of the total reparations debt owed to Black Charlotteans, across all categories of documented harm, in 2024 present value.

35,000

Eligible Residents

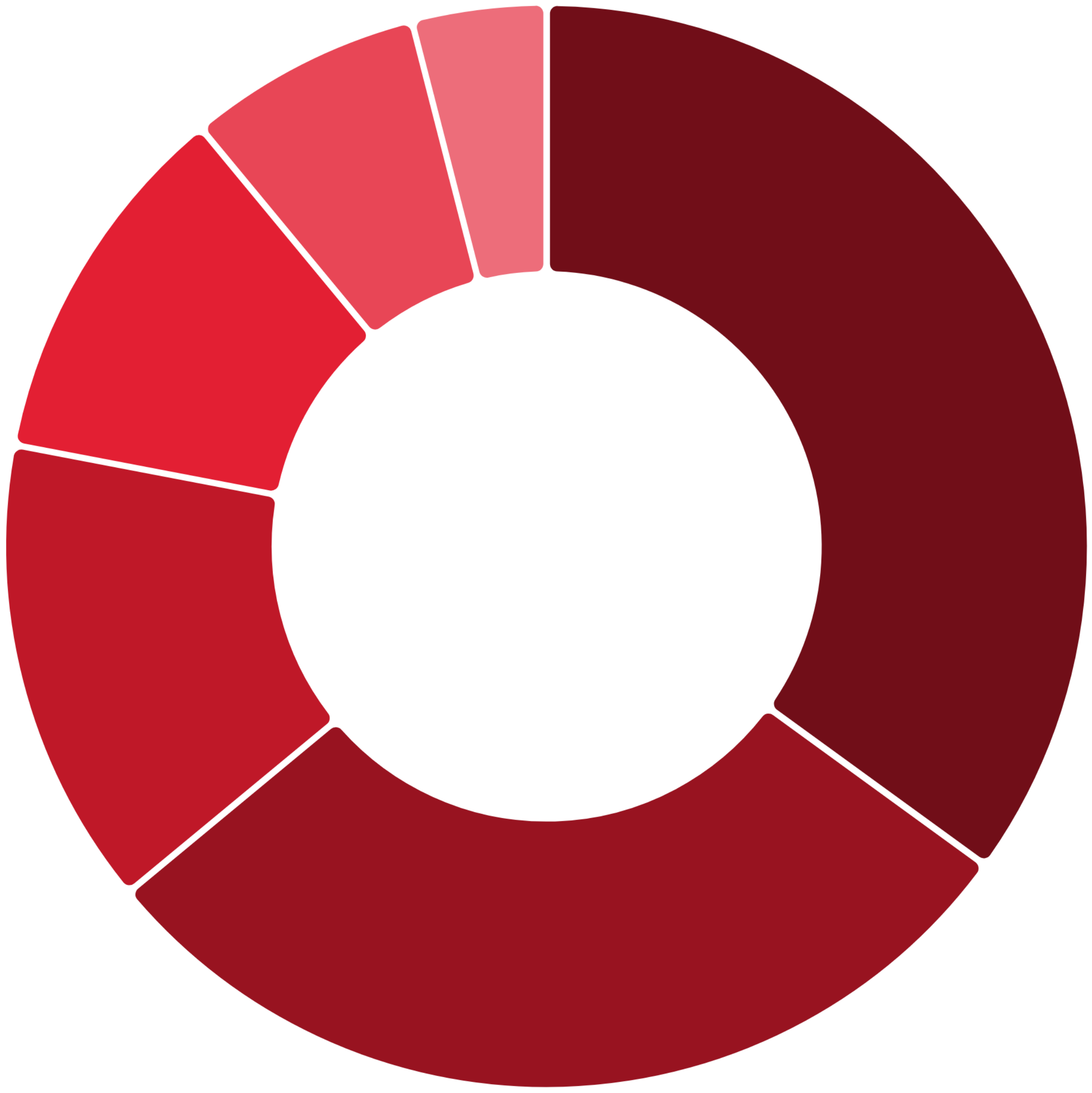
Estimated number of current and formerly resident Black Charlotteans and their direct descendants who would qualify for reparations under an eligibility framework modeled on the San Francisco AARAC standard.

$3.7M

Per Eligible Recipient

Total liability divided by eligible recipients yields approximately $3.7 million per person — a figure that reflects Charlotte's specific pattern and scale of harm.

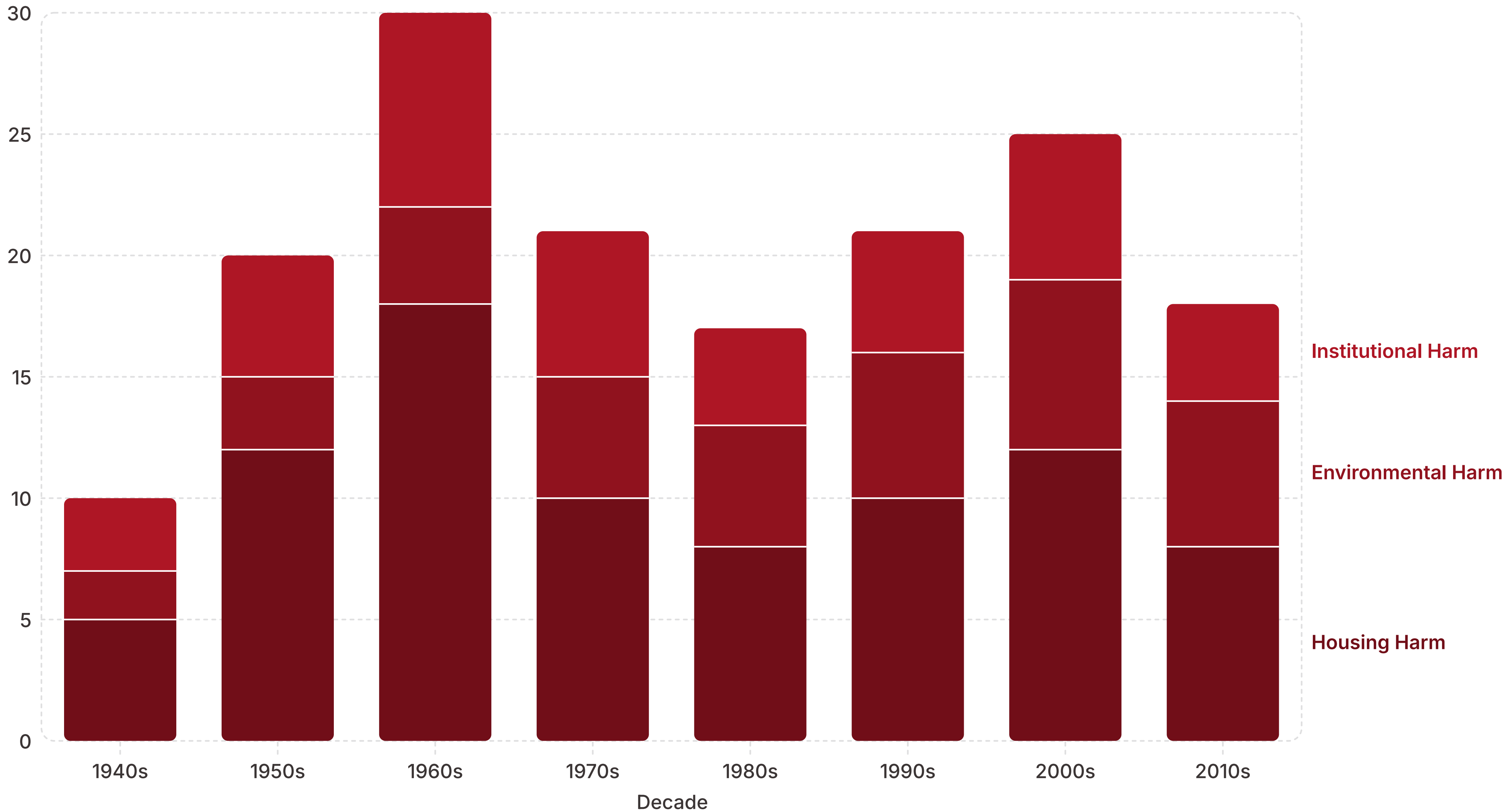
Reparations Liability Distribution by Responsible Party



- Federal Government (FHA, HUD, Dept. of Army) · 35%
- City and County of Charlotte/Mecklenburg · 29%
- State of North Carolina · 14%
- Financial Institutions (Wells Fargo, BofA predecessors) · 11%
- Corporations (Duke Energy, Developers) · 7%
- Insurance Companies · 4%

The federal government bears the largest single share of reparations liability, given its central role in designing and enforcing redlining through the FHA and HOLC, and its direct responsibility for the munitions infrastructure placed in Black Charlotte neighborhoods. The City and County of Charlotte is the second largest obligor. No responsible party escapes liability — and none has fully acknowledged it.

Reparations Growth of Harm Over Time



This chart illustrates the cumulative accumulation of harm across three principal categories over eight decades. Note that harm did not end with the Civil Rights Act — environmental harm has grown as industrial infrastructure remained in Black neighborhoods, and institutional harm from discriminatory lending peaked in the 2000s subprime crisis and continues to be documented in 2026 mortgage data.

What Reparations Are and Are Not

What Reparations ARE

- A legal remedy for documented, specific harms
- A transfer of unjustly withheld wealth back to its rightful heirs
- A mechanism for closing the racial wealth gap
- Acknowledgment that racism was policy, not prejudice
- An investment in community health, housing, and education
- Consistent with American legal and constitutional tradition

What Reparations ARE NOT

- A gift or charitable transfer
- An act of guilt or blame on individual white people
- Unprecedented — America has paid reparations before
- Unaffordable — Charlotte's annual city budget exceeds $3 billion
- A final solution — reparations are one component of systemic repair
- Optional — they are a legal and moral obligation

The Right to Return: A Core Reparative Demand

Monetary reparations, while essential, are insufficient without addressing the spatial dimension of Black displacement from Charlotte's historic urban core. The right to return — supported by the United Nations' Principles on Housing and Property Restitution — requires that displaced persons and their descendants have the right to reclaim their original community. For Black Charlotteans, this means the construction of permanently affordable housing in the Second Ward/Brooklyn footprint, the Historic West End, and Cherry; a dedicated land trust for Black homeownership; a first right of return for eligible descendants; and the conversion of unused city-owned land in historically Black neighborhoods to community ownership. Without these structural interventions, monetary payments risk being absorbed by the very housing market that displaced Black residents in the first place.

Structural Reparations: Beyond the Check

Housing Restitution

Construction of 5,000 permanently affordable homes in historically Black neighborhoods including Second Ward, the West End, Biddleville, and Cherry; a Black Community Land Trust capitalized at $500 million; first right of purchase for displaced families in any city-funded development on former Brooklyn land or adjacent areas.

Educational Investment

Free tuition at Johnson C. Smith University and Central Piedmont Community College for eligible Black residents and their descendants; dedicated endowment for Black student scholarships and HBCU partnerships; restorative curriculum in CMS that teaches the full history of Black Charlotte including Brooklyn, the Swann case, and urban renewal.

Economic Development

A $1 billion Black Business Development Fund providing grants and zero-interest loans; set-asides of 30% of city contracting for Black-owned firms; preference in Brooklyn Village and other redevelopment projects for Black-owned development firms and construction contractors.

Health and Environment

Full environmental remediation of contaminated West Charlotte sites with independent community oversight; a community health trust of $300 million providing free medical screening and treatment for residents of historically polluted neighborhoods; air quality monitoring with enforcement; Duke Energy accountability for coal ash contamination of Charlotte's water supply.

The Moral Case: Why "Moving On" Is Not an Option

> "A man who robs you of your wallet does not become innocent by spending the money. A city that destroys a community does not become just by building a new stadium on the rubble. The debt does not age. The obligation does not expire. The only question is whether we have the courage to pay it."
>
> *— Negro Research Institute*

The most common objection to reparations — that too much time has passed — collapses under the weight of the evidence. The harms documented in this brief are not merely historical. They are active. Duke Energy's coal ash contamination of Charlotte's drinking water source is present and ongoing. The discriminatory denial of mortgages to Black applicants in Charlotte by Wells Fargo was documented as recently as 2026. Gentrification is displacing Black communities that were themselves the product of prior displacement. Mecklenburg County received an "F" for air quality — and Black neighborhoods bear the greatest exposure. The statute of limitations does not run on a continuing tort — and the racial harm visited upon Black Charlotteans has never stopped.

The International Dimension: A Global Obligation

The world is watching Charlotte — not merely as a local political story, but as a test of whether the New South can deliver justice to the people it has most profoundly wronged. Charlotte brands itself as a progressive, globally connected financial capital. That brand carries an obligation. The United Nations Special Rapporteur on Contemporary Forms of Racism has repeatedly cited American cities' reparations processes as models of municipal-level accountability. Governments in the United Kingdom, Canada, the Netherlands, and across the Caribbean — all former slave-trading or slaveholding states — are monitoring American cities as they face their own reparations debates. What Charlotte does will resonate far beyond its borders. The Queen City has an opportunity to lead. The question is whether it has the will.

Voices From the Community: Testimony on Record

"My grandmother had a business in Brooklyn. The city came and took it. They gave her almost nothing. She moved to the West End, raised her kids near that highway they built through our neighborhood. My mother has asthma. I have asthma. My nephew has asthma. How many generations have to pay before we get paid?"

— West Charlotte resident, community forum testimony

"We built this city. We are in the concrete of every building the Redevelopment Commission put up after they tore ours down. We are owed. Not just money — we are owed acknowledgment, we are owed apology, we are owed restoration."

— Former Brooklyn neighborhood resident's descendant, Charlotte NAACP public hearing

"Every time I look at what they built on Brooklyn — the offices, the parking lots — I think about what was there before. Every time I smell the pollution near the West Side, I think about who decided that was okay. I know who decided. And I know they need to make it right."

— Historic West End longtime resident, community forum testimony

The Pathway Forward: A Six-Point Action Plan

01

Pass a Binding Reparations Ordinance

The Charlotte City Council must pass a binding ordinance — not a resolution — establishing direct cash payments, a reparations trust fund, and a permanent oversight body with subpoena power to enforce compliance by all city departments and contractors.

02

Establish Liability Against Corporate Actors

The Charlotte City Attorney must file suit or open formal administrative proceedings against Duke Energy, Wells Fargo, Bank of America predecessors, and other named corporate actors for their documented roles in Black community harm. Settlement proceeds must flow directly to the reparations fund.

03

Demand Federal Co-Payment

Charlotte must formally demand that the federal government fund its proportionate share of reparations liability — particularly for redlining (FHA/HOLC), the Army munitions plant sited in a Black neighborhood, and discriminatory federal contracting practices — through Congressional appropriations and executive action.

04

Complete Environmental Remediation

Full, independently verified environmental remediation of contaminated West Charlotte sites must be completed under community oversight. All costs must be borne by the responsible parties — Duke Energy, legacy industrial operators, and city government — not taxpayers in the affected communities.

05

Halt and Reverse Gentrification of Surviving Black Communities

The city must implement anti-displacement protections for Biddleville, Cherry, and the Historic West End — the surviving remnants of Black Charlotte — including community land trusts, right-to-return policies, and anti-speculation taxes on properties in historically Black neighborhoods.

06

Build the Black Community Land Trust

The city must transfer surplus public land in the Second Ward/Brooklyn footprint and the Historic West End to a permanent Black Community Land Trust, capitalized at no less than $500 million, with governance controlled by Black Charlotteans and their descendants.

Reparations Liability by Entity: The Named Defendants

Entity	Primary Harm Category	Estimated Liability (Billions)
U.S. Federal Government (FHA, HUD, Dept. of Army)	Redlining, munitions plant siting, contract exclusion	45.7
City and County of Charlotte / Mecklenburg	Urban renewal, environmental zoning, policing, highway routing	37.8
State of North Carolina	Education inequity, state housing policy	18.3
Wells Fargo and Bank of America (predecessors)	Mortgage discrimination, predatory lending	10.2
Duke Energy	Environmental harm, coal ash contamination, discriminatory infrastructure	7.1
Real estate developers (Brooklyn redevelopment)	Unjust enrichment from displaced community land	5.1
Insurance industry (State Farm, Allstate, etc.)	Discriminatory pricing and denial of coverage	6.3
Other corporate actors	Contracting exclusion, business discrimination, industrial pollution	0
TOTAL		**130.5**

Summary of the Case: The Verdict the Evidence Demands

The Record Is Clear

Every harm documented in this brief is supported by government records, court decisions, academic research, and community testimony. This is not advocacy built on grievance — it is a legal brief built on evidence.

The Law Is Clear

Unjust enrichment, tortious harm, constitutional violation, statutory civil rights violation, and international human rights law all converge on the same conclusion: the debt is real and legally enforceable.

The Amount Is Clear

The Negro Research Institute calculates a minimum reparations obligation of $130.5 billion — owed by federal, state, and municipal governments and by named corporate actors — to Black Charlotteans and their descendants.

The Time Is Now

The harm is ongoing. The obligation does not expire. Every year of delay compounds both the damage and the debt. Charlotte has the opportunity to lead the New South. The question is whether it has the will.

The Closing Argument: For the Record, for the World

Submitted by the Negro Research Institute

> We have presented the evidence. We have named the perpetrators. We have calculated the damages. We have identified the legal remedies. We have shown that precedent exists and that the law demands action. The case for reparations for African Americans in Charlotte, North Carolina is not merely strong — it is **airtight**. The only question that remains is not one of law, or economics, or history. It is one of character. Will Charlotte — will North Carolina — will America — be the kind of nation that honors its debts? The world is watching. History is recording. The verdict belongs to those who choose justice over convenience. We rest our case.

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CHARLOTTE, NORTH CAROLINA REPARATIONS BRIEF, 2024